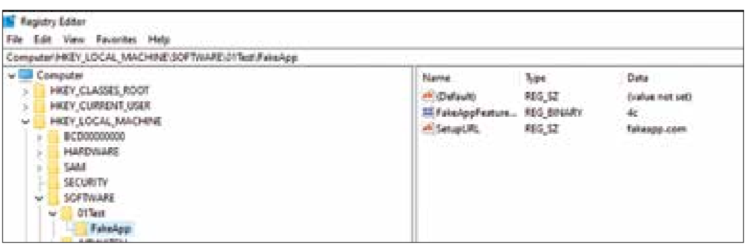
- HKEY_CURRENT_CONFIG or HKCC (only in Windows 95/98/ME and NT-based versions of Windows)
- HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT or HKCR
- HKEY_CURRENT_USER or HKCU
- HKEY_USERS or HKU
- HKEY_PERFORMANCE_DATA (only in NT-based versions of Windows, but invisible in the Windows Registry Editor)
- HKEY_DYN_DATA (only in Windows 95/98/ME, and visible in the Windows Registry Editor)

All registry keys may be controlled by access control lists (ACLs) based on user privileges, security tokens acquired by apps, or system security policies imposed by the system, just like other files and services in Windows. (These limitations may be set by the system and configured by local system administrators or domain administrators.) Users, programmes, services, and remote systems may only see certain parts of the hierarchy or different hierarchies from the same root keys.

HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE (HKLM)

The key indicated by HKLM is not saved on disc, but rather in memory by the system kernel, which uses it to map all other subkeys. Additional subkeys cannot be created by applications. This key has four subkeys, “SAM”, “SECURITY”, “SYSTEM”, and “SOFTWARE”, which are loaded at boot time within their respective files in the %SystemRoot%System32config folder on NT-based versions of Windows. The fifth subkey, “HARDWARE,” is volatile and dynamically formed, thus it is not saved in a file (it exposes a view of all the currently detected Plug-and-Play devices). The kernel maps the sixth subkey in memory and populates it with boot configuration data (BCD) for Windows Vista, Windows Server 2008, Windows Server 2008 R2, and Windows 7.



Typical key-value pair structure